IELTS ACADEMIC · RESTRICTED STAFF MATERIAL

IELTS Academic Set 31

PRIVATE STAFF answer key and Listening transcript

RESTRICTED STAFF COPY

RESTRICTED STAFF COPY. Contains answer keys and Listening transcripts. Do not distribute to candidates.

Answer keys and Listening transcripts are restricted to staff.

Listening

Question	Answer	Accepted variants
1	Lomax	
2	cello case	
3	broken latch	
4	heavy canvas	
5	Friday morning	
6	rear entrance	
7	zip	
8	rainwater	
9	email	
10	48 pounds	
11	A	
12	F	
13	C	
14	H	
15	D	
16	B	
17	E	
18	A	
19	D	

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Question	Answer	Accepted variants
20	C	
21	B	
22	C	
23	A	
24	C	
25	B	
26	D	
27	A	
28	E	
29	B	
30	C	
31	manganese	
32	clay	
33	microbes	
34	dust	
35	surface stability	
36	episodes	
37	C	
38	A	
39	B	
40	C	

Listening transcript

Part 1 - everyday social dialogue

Osric Pym	Good morning, Lomax Instrument Repairs. How can I help?
Cerys Lomax	Hi. My surname is Lomax, L-O-M-A-X. I rang yesterday about a damaged cello case, not the cello itself.
Osric Pym	Yes, I have the enquiry here. Before we open a job, I need to confirm the customer name and the item, so that the case is not entered as an instrument repair. Let me add a note to the file about how the case is normally carried. The repairer needs to know whether it travels upright on public transport or flat in a car, because that affects the pressure on the fastening.
Cerys Lomax	Mostly upright, and I take it on trains twice a week.

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Osric Pym	I'll record that so the new fitting is tested in the relevant position.
Cerys Lomax	The case still protects the cello, but the broken latch no longer holds the lid shut. The hinges are sound.
Osric Pym	Then we can replace the latch without rebuilding the frame. You mentioned a plastic rain sleeve on the phone.
Cerys Lomax	I did, but I need something suitable for wet platforms. Which material would you recommend?
Osric Pym	For that, I'd recommend our tougher canvas cover with sealed seams. It costs a little more, but it is the version we use for cases carried outdoors frequently.
Cerys Lomax	That sounds worth the extra cost. Please put the heavy canvas cover on the order.
Osric Pym	We could have it ready late Thursday, although the adhesive needs a full night to set. Friday morning would be safer for collection.
Cerys Lomax	That suits me. Which door should I use? Last time I came through the showroom.
Osric Pym	For repaired cases, please use the rear entrance; it opens directly onto the collection bench. When you arrive, ring the bell labelled Repairs rather than leaving the case at the delivery hatch. A technician will ask you to check the latch action before signing. If it feels too stiff, we can adjust it while you wait; taking it away and forcing it could damage the wooden rim.
Cerys Lomax	I also noticed that the zip on the music pocket sticks. Is that included?
Osric Pym	The zip itself is worn, so I will put replacement rather than lubrication on the estimate. The brown mark beside it looks like tea in the photograph.
Cerys Lomax	It is actually rainwater; it came through the damaged seam during a walk from the station. Could you quote for cleaning separately rather than include it automatically?
Osric Pym	Certainly. I'll separate the essential latch and zip work from the optional cleaning. We cannot promise that an old water mark will disappear completely, but if you approve the treatment, I'll attach before-and-after photographs.
Cerys Lomax	That sounds sensible. Please list the cleaning as optional.
Osric Pym	We will inspect the lining before quoting. Would you like the estimate by text?
Cerys Lomax	Email, please, because I need to forward it to the orchestra manager. She has authorised up to forty-eight pounds, including the cover. If the work will cost more than £48, call me before ordering anything.
Osric Pym	Certainly; no additional work will begin without approval. Your authorisation limit includes tax and ordinary materials. If we discover that the internal frame is cracked, the technician will stop and send a revised estimate rather than substituting a more expensive fitting.
Cerys Lomax	Perfect. I need a clear record for the orchestra's accounts.
Osric Pym	The email will show labour, parts and the optional cover on separate lines.

Part 2 - everyday social monologue

Tabitha Crowle	Welcome to Bramley Signal Box. Keep the plan in front of you. You entered from the south, and reception is the first marked point on the left, at A. The doorway immediately beside it is staff-only, so follow the visitor symbol rather than the historic sign above the door.

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Tabitha Crowle	From reception the level route turns east. The accessible ramp is at F, beside the newer glazed door. The stone steps farther north are part of the original building but are not on the public route. The ramp has handrails on both sides and reaches the same landing as the lift.
Tabitha Crowle	Continue west across the central hall. The viewing platform is C. Its dark non-slip floor marks the safe stopping line, and it lets visitors see the machinery without entering the working area. The nearby open doorway is only a store, so do not treat it as another viewing point.
Tabitha Crowle	Behind the platform is the lever frame, marked H. It contains the long painted levers once used to control points and signals. Several still connect to preserved equipment below the floor, which is why visitors must remain behind the brass rail.
Tabitha Crowle	The token room is D, opposite the information point. Its small instruments once controlled access to a single-track section. Although the room looks like an office on the plan, its public entrance is clearly marked from the main passage.
Tabitha Crowle	Visitors who need a quiet pause can use the bench at B, across the path from reception. It is screened from the busiest circulation route but remains visible to staff. Please leave the space free for anyone who needs to sit rather than using it to store bags.
Tabitha Crowle	Now for today’s activities. The morning signal demonstration takes place at the lever frame, option E on your activity list. It begins at ten fifteen. The guide moves only three selected levers; the rest are secured. Photography is permitted without flash, and bags must stay beneath the bench so the narrow aisle remains clear.
Tabitha Crowle	The token exchange demonstration is in the token room, option A. The guide uses replicas to show how a physical token prevented two trains from entering the same section. Original instruments stay behind glass, but the demonstration follows the historical sequence closely.
Tabitha Crowle	The family activity is in the retired carriage, option D. Children can sort replica tickets and build a simple timetable there. It is close to the token room, but the two sessions have different meeting points and are intended for different audiences.
Tabitha Crowle	Finally, the accessible tour starts at the viewing platform, option C. Everyone can gather there without blocking reception, and the guide can check the lift and hearing loop before the group moves on. The general tour starts elsewhere, so arrive five minutes early and wait on the platform.
Tabitha Crowle	A few practical points before you set off: the working floor closes before the shop, step-free parking must be booked in advance, and late arrivals should wait at reception rather than crossing a demonstration route. The visitor plan sometimes looks less direct than the old staff passages, but its route protects both people and the operating machinery.
Tabitha Crowle	The labels on the building deserve a final word. Some name the room’s railway purpose, while the plan names its current visitor function. Use the plan for navigation and the historic labels for interpretation. Volunteers in blue badges can explain any difference. At closing time, follow the illuminated visitor arrows; staff may secure the working floor before the rest of the site, and a route that was open in the morning may then be unavailable. Printed large-type guides are available beside reception.

Part 3 - educational/training discussion

Noemi Farrow	I moved our first water-sampling site about two hundred metres upstream. After last week’s rain, the bank at the original point collapsed, and it is no longer safe to stand there.
Kieran Moss	Does the replacement still give us a fair comparison?

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Noemi Farrow	Yes. Flow, depth and shade are close to the original conditions. We measured the depth and photographed the canopy rather than simply assuming that the sites were alike.
Kieran Moss	I understand the site change. What exactly does the field blank test?
Noemi Farrow	We take sterile water into the field, open it beside the real samples and handle it with the same equipment. If DNA appears in that blank, contamination was probably introduced during field handling rather than coming from the river.
Kieran Moss	So it travels in the same cooler and stays open for the same length of time, but never touches river water.
Noemi Farrow	Exactly. If it is positive, we review gloves, bottle handling and work surfaces before interpreting the river samples.
Kieran Moss	For labels, could we just write the river name on each lid?
Noemi Farrow	No, lids can become separated from bottles. We'll use waterproof labels with coded numbers, then copy every code into the field log. One person will read the code aloud while the other checks the entry.
Kieran Moss	And the code should identify the site, replicate and time without revealing which species we expect.
Noemi Farrow	Right. We also change gloves between sites and after handling ropes or measuring equipment, even when the gloves still look clean.
Kieran Moss	If all three bottles give a negative result, can we report that the species is absent?
Noemi Farrow	No. DNA may be present below the detection limit or distributed unevenly. We should report non-detection and the number of replicates, not turn an uncertain result into proof of absence.
Kieran Moss	Let's check the controls for the second question block. How are we reducing contamination from boats?
Noemi Farrow	We'll lower the bottle from a clean launch point upstream of the moorings, where ropes and hull wash are less likely to affect the sample.
Kieran Moss	The field blank covers handling. What checks the laboratory stage?
Noemi Farrow	An extraction blank. It enters when the laboratory reagents are added, so a signal there points to contamination introduced during extraction rather than at the river.
Kieran Moss	Weather and water level could still differ between sites.
Noemi Farrow	That is why both sites will be sampled within a matched tidal window. It will not remove every environmental difference, but it limits variation caused by changing water volume.
Kieran Moss	What about the journey back to the laboratory?
Noemi Farrow	We'll use chilled transport: the bottles remain cool but are not frozen, and the courier time is recorded.
Kieran Moss	Finally, how many samples at each point?
Noemi Farrow	Triplicate samples. Three independent bottles help us recognise an anomalous result, and we can report how many replicates were positive rather than only a yes-or-no conclusion.

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Kieran Moss	I'll print the labels, calibrate the meter and confirm collection. You'll prepare sterile bottles and the blanks. At each site, one person handles the pole while the other records time, rainfall, boat traffic and water conditions.
Noemi Farrow	We should also pre-register when an extraction will be repeated. Making that decision only after seeing a weak signal would invite bias. A short pilot at the campus pond can rehearse the sequence, but it will not enter the dataset.
Kieran Moss	The report also needs a clear distinction between detecting target DNA and demonstrating a living local population. Water, birds or equipment can move genetic material beyond the place where the organism lives.
Noemi Farrow	Agreed. We'll interpret the result alongside flow, recent rainfall and boat traffic, and we'll publish the quality-control outcomes even if they complicate the story. Excluding an inconvenient blank after seeing the results would make the design impossible to audit.
Kieran Moss	Back in the laboratory, filenames should preserve the field codes rather than replace them with species names. That keeps analysts blind to our expectation during extraction and makes every result traceable to its bottle, time and replicate. We will retain the original log sheets after transcription, record every correction rather than overwriting it, and reconcile bottle counts before opening the cooler. If a seal is broken or a code cannot be matched, the sample will be quarantined and reported as excluded instead of silently reassigned.

Part 4 - academic monologue

Lecturer	Rock varnish is the dark, extremely thin coating seen on stable stone surfaces in many dry landscapes. The darkest layers are especially rich in manganese oxides; paler bands may contain more iron, so colour alone cannot identify how a coating formed. Early accounts treated varnish almost like paint applied steadily by the environment. Modern studies instead begin with microscopic structure and local exposure history. A coating may appear black at a distance yet contain alternating layers only micrometres thick. Some layers are rich in manganese, others in clay or iron. This fine structure is one reason bulk colour measurements are insufficient: different histories can produce surfaces that look broadly similar to the unaided eye.
Lecturer	The coating is a mixture rather than a single mineral layer. Fine clay contributes to its matrix, while airborne dust supplies both particles and trace elements. Rain, dew and surface films can move that material over very short distances. Microbes may alter local chemistry and influence where manganese becomes concentrated, although no universal microbial mechanism explains every sample. Dust composition changes with geology, land use and wind direction. Researchers collect nearby airborne material and compare it with particles trapped in the varnish. A chemical resemblance can identify a plausible source, but it does not by itself explain why particles adhere or why one face becomes more strongly coated than another.
Lecturer	Surface stability is crucial. A boulder that rolls, a face that flakes or a channel repeatedly scoured by sand cannot retain a continuous coating. This is one reason varnish thickness fails to provide a dependable age. Growth occurs in episodes, separated by pauses whose duration varies with erosion, renewed deposition and changes in microclimate. Biological hypotheses are tested by locating cells, pigments or molecular traces within intact layers, not merely by finding microbes on an exposed surface. Even then, association is not proof of control. Organisms may colonise a coating after its mineral structure has already developed.

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Lecturer	Researchers therefore combine microscopic, chemical and environmental evidence. They compare texture, elemental composition, slope, exposure and nearby dust sources. A dark patch on a sheltered face may not have the same history as a visually similar patch exposed to wind. Equally, a newly detached flake may reveal an uncoated surface beneath an older layer. Dating attempts sometimes compare varnish with independently dated rock surfaces, but the relationship is rarely linear. A stable surface can experience pulses of deposition separated by erosion or inactivity. The useful question is often whether a coating predates or postdates a known event, not its exact calendar age.
Lecturer	The safest conclusion is not that one process is always dominant, but that several interacting processes must be evaluated together. Varnish can preserve useful environmental signals, yet those signals are filtered by the stability and history of the surface. Interpretation becomes stronger when it explains both coated and uncoated areas, rather than selecting only the most dramatic example. Good sampling is deliberately comparative. Investigators take material from different orientations and include bare controls, then document precisely where each fragment came from. Because removal is destructive and cultural sites may be protected, analytical methods increasingly aim to obtain more information from smaller samples.
Lecturer	There is also an ethical dimension to interpretation. Dark coatings occur on archaeological structures and rock art panels, where destructive sampling may damage irreplaceable evidence. Researchers first use photography, portable spectroscopy and microscopic imaging, then request a fragment only when the question cannot be answered non-invasively. They record permits, sampling positions and the mass removed. Results should distinguish observations from inference: detecting manganese, clay and microbial material describes composition, whereas proposing a formation pathway requires comparison and experimental support. The most informative studies combine field context with laboratory analysis and acknowledge when several explanations remain plausible. That caution is not a weakness. It prevents a complex surface archive from being reduced to a simple clock or attributed to one fashionable mechanism without adequate evidence.
Lecturer	Environmental change adds another complication. A surface now exposed to pollution, irrigation spray or altered drainage may be accumulating material under conditions unlike those that produced its older layers. Cross-sections can sometimes reveal a recent outer zone over a slower historical sequence, but interpreting that boundary requires independent records of land use and climate. Experimental stones placed in the same landscape help measure present-day deposition, although a short experiment cannot reproduce centuries of weathering. Researchers also avoid assuming that adjacent faces share one history: shade, runoff and salt crystallisation can vary over a few centimetres. For this reason, sampling design and field notes are as important as sophisticated instruments. The laboratory can describe a tiny fragment precisely, but only its documented position allows that description to answer a wider geological or archaeological question.

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Reading

Question	Answer	Accepted variants
1	porous clay	
2	wet sand	
3	evaporation	
4	inner pot	
5	shade	
6	airflow	
7	humidity	
8	B	
9	C	
10	D	
11	E	
12	F	
13	G	
14	H	
15	I	
16	IV	
17	II	
18	VI	
19	III	
20	V	
21	A	
22	B	
23	C	
24	A	
25	B	
26	C	
27	YES	
28	NO	

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.

Question	Answer	Accepted variants
29	NOT GIVEN	
30	YES	
31	NO	
32	ensemble spread	
33	probabilities	
34	systematic bias	
35	calibrated	
36	thresholds	
37	B	
38	C	
39	A	
40	D	

© 2026 Idiomas WeLearn. Todos los derechos reservados. · idiomaswl.com
Uso personal y educativo. Prohibida su reproducción, venta o distribución sin autorización escrita.